TEACHING DEMONSTRATION · ENTREPRENEURSHIP

Exploring Unique Marketing *Issues.*

What entrepreneurs face now that generative AI answers the search.

Understanding **Generative Engine Optimisation (GEO)** through foundational marketing: STP, brand, the marketing mix, and closing the deal with the sales steps.

LECTURER

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DATE

5 November 2026

A3, Central Administration

CASE STUDY · NO. 01

RUKA MALDIVES

THE CASE

Ruka Maldives, Dhiffushi, North Malé Atoll. A real twelve-room boutique guesthouse with a cosy, boho, island-villa feel, used with the owner's permission.

THE CASE

Meet *Ruka Maldives*

- **Dhiffushi,** North Malé Atoll · 12 rooms · opened 2025
- **Cosy boutique,** boho style, a personal island-villa feel
- **Open-courtyard** and indoor dining · serviced living
- **Budget-friendly,** and no website of its own

Four questions every new venture must answer:

01 — STP

Who are our customers, and how do we find them?

Segment the market, choose targets, state one clear position.

Canvas: Customer Segments + Value Proposition

02 — BRAND

Why us? How does a brand decide whether AI finds you?

A consistent brand earns trust despite the liability of newness.

Canvas: Value Proposition

03 — 4PS → 7PS

What do we offer, and how?

The 4Ps become 7Ps, because a guesthouse sells a service.

Canvas: Channels + Revenue Streams

04 — SALES

Closing the deal: can selling be a repeatable system?

No one can guarantee a sale; the seven-step process makes it repeatable.

Canvas: Customer Relationships

Barringer & Ireland, “Unique Marketing Issues”: written for new ventures facing the liability of newness



iocdrp.s.gy/ruka

YOUR TURN

Be the *traveller.*

01 Scan the code with your camera

02 Pick a traveller: Couple, Solo, Family or Dive

03 Tap Search and read the AI’s answer

04 Watch the screen

Pause at the question: “Why do you think the AI left Ruka out?”

● SIMULATION · MODELLED ON OUR FIELD TEST, 4 NOV 2026

Same question, asked in the UK and in China.

They use completely different AI engines. The result is the same: **no Ruka.**

cosy guesthouse near Malé for a honeymoon, not too expensive **Search**

我们是情侣，想找马尔代夫马累附近温馨又不太贵的民宿 **Search**

Gemini / Google AI · UK (English)

cosy guesthouse near Malé for a honeymoon, not too expensive

Here are three cosy picks near Malé:

1. **Stone Hotels Dhiffushi**
   Dhiffushi · rooftop infinity pool, spa, private beach
2. **Arena Beach Hotel**
   Maafushi · private beach, 50 rooms
3. **Crystal Sands**

Baidu AI · China (中文)

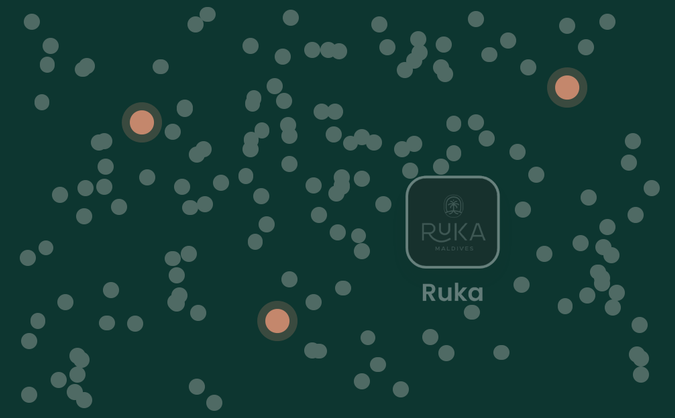
我们是情侣，想找马尔代夫马累附近温馨又不太贵的民宿

为您推荐以下三家：

1. **Arena Beach Hotel**
   Maafushi · private beach, 50 rooms
2. **Crystal Sands**
3. **Stone Hotels Dhiffushi**
   Dhiffushi · rooftop infinity pool, spa, private beach

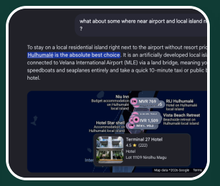
WHY did both AIs skip Ruka?

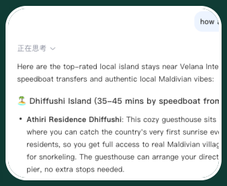
PLACES TO STAY NEAR MALÉ ~150 · illustrative



0 times **Ruka Maldives** was named







Real answers, 4 Nov 2026 · Gemini · Google AI Mode · Baidu

OBJECTIVE ONE · SEGMENT

Who *could* stay?

Segmentation divides a market into groups of customers with similar needs.

Barringer & Ireland, Unique Marketing Issues

DEMOGRAPHIC	Age, income, life stage: honeymooners, young families
GEOGRAPHIC	Where guests come from: Europe, China, South Asia
PSYCHOGRAPHIC	Lifestyle and values: boho aesthetic versus luxury resort
BEHAVIOURAL	Benefit sought: a budget stay versus diving every day

MALDIVES TOURIST SEGMENTS

Couples & honeymooners

Romance, privacy and a special setting

Solo travellers

Quiet, safety and value for money

Small families

Space, easy meals and a budget that works

Divers

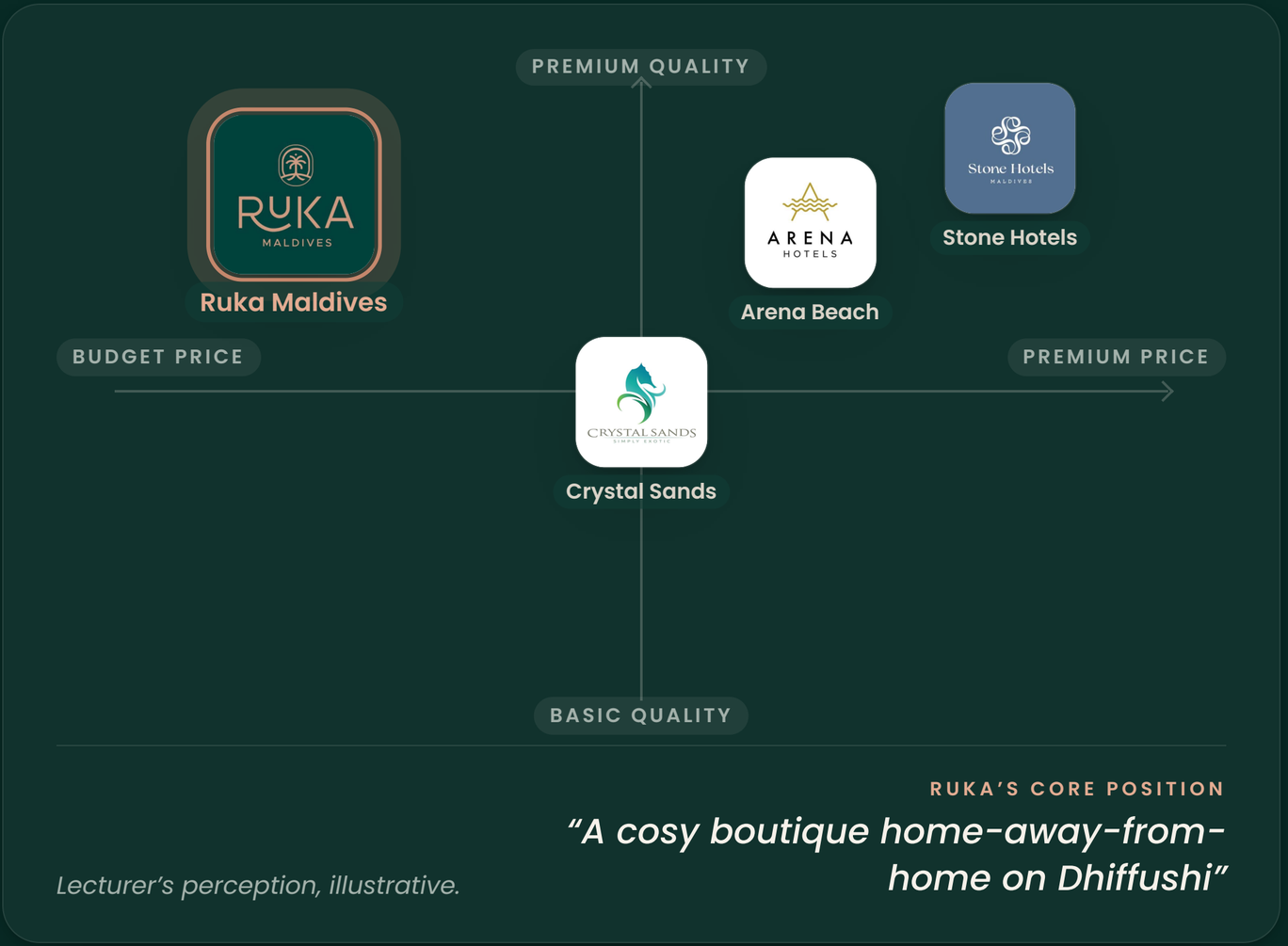
A dive centre on site and daily dive trips

TARGET · POSITION

Target where you can *win*

Choose the segments where a new venture has a **real advantage**; do not chase everyone.

- **Couples & honeymooners**
- **Solo travellers**
- **Small families**
- ~~**Divers: left out**~~
  Reveries Diving Village has a dive centre on site



Perceptual map: price × quality of experience

OBJECTIVE TWO · BRAND

A brand is a promise people, *and AI,* recognise

> "A brand is the set of attributes, positive or negative, that people associate with a company."
>
> *Barringer & Ireland, Unique Marketing Issues*

Liability of newness
No track record, so the brand must create trust

Difference
Stands out from look-alike guesthouses

Brand equity
Consistent signals add up to value and loyalty

Recognition
People and AI recommend what they can identify

TEACHING SCENARIO

EVERYWHERE

Ruka Maldives

Same name · same address · same phone

Every review and booking now counts for one brand, one entity an AI can recognise.

Name · Address · Phone, identical everywhere

AI LENS · STP + BRAND

Through the AI lens: *STP + brand* together

01 — STP · SEGMENT

Reads the intent

"cosy, budget, honeymoon"

= a segment: **couples on a budget**

02 — BRAND

Checks the facts

Same name, address, phone and facts across

Listings · Maps · Reviews · Social

03 — STP · POSITION

Shortlists

The **position** it can verify and repeat

A POSITION IS PROVABLE WHEN…

- ✓ The **same facts** appear everywhere
- ✓ **Specific attributes** replace adjectives
- ✓ **Reviews echo** the position

ONE BRAND, THREE PROOF POINTS

Couples: intimate boho style and courtyard dining

Solo: privacy and serviced living on a budget

Families: villa-style living, indoor and courtyard dining

Morand & Schegg (2026), *Be Visible to AI*, HES-SO Valais-Wallis (practitioner white paper)

The marketing mix in the *generative* era

STANDARD GEO VERSION

Marketing 5.0: technology reshapes every P *Kotler, Kartajaya & Setiawan (2021)*

P1 Product GEO

Facts, not adjectives: 12 boho rooms, courtyard dining, breakfast included. AI repeats what it can check.

P2 Price GEO

Publish a range and terms, so AI can qualify the guest before it recommends.

P3 Place GEO

AI assistants are the newest intermediary: keep every listing consistent.

P4 Promotion GEO

Structured content and reviews that AI can extract and summarise.

+ SERVICE PS · BOOMS & BITNER (1981); WIRTZ & LOVELOCK (2022)

P5 People

Hosts named and reviewed consistently.

P6 Process

Clear booking and response steps an AI can describe.

P7 Physical evidence

Real photos of the boho rooms and courtyard, the same on every listing.

OBJECTIVE FOUR · CLOSING THE DEAL

AI opens doors; *you* close the sale

AI DOES THIS TODAY

1

Prospect for leads

Find travellers looking for a Dhiffushi stay

2

Initial contact

The first answer to an enquiry

3

Qualify the lead

Budget, dates and fit confirmed

4

Sales presentation

Rooms, courtyard and breakfast shown

HUMAN

5

Meet objections

"Can you arrange a courtyard dinner for our anniversary?"

6

Close the sale

Deposit and confirmation

7

Follow-up

Reviews, repeat stays, referrals

Steps one to four: the AI finds, filters and presents for you. A guest who clicks through arrives pre-qualified.

Steps five to seven: objections, the close and the relationship still belong to the guesthouse.

No one can guarantee a sale; a process makes it repeatable.

DISCUSSION

If AI handles steps one to four, how does the guesthouse manager's role change?

1 Prospect | 2 Contact | 3 Qualify | 4 Present | 5 Objections | 6 Close | 7 Follow-up

AI-ASSISTED | HUMAN

Turn to your neighbour. Which touchpoints should stay human, and which can be automated?

01 Administrative responder → experience architect.

Why: AI now answers rates, dates and availability, so the manager's value moves to steps 5–7: objections like the anniversary courtyard dinner, the close, and the stay itself.

02 Passive marketer → data curator.

Why: the AI only recommends what it can verify, so keeping name, facts, prices and photos identical everywhere becomes a daily job.

Reviews from great stays feed the next AI answer.

Now tap Search again.

TRAVELLER: A COUPLE / HONEYMOON

1. *Ruka Maldives*
2. Stone Hotels Dhiffushi
3. Arena Beach Hotel

- **Solo & family:** Ruka moves up the list
- **Dive:** still not a fit; Reveries wins

YOUR TURN

Now, make Ruka *visible.*

BRAND	One name, address and phone everywhere
PRODUCT	Facts: boho style, courtyard dining, serviced living
PRICE	A clear price range and terms, published
PLACE	Bookable direct and on OTAs, details identical

Picked the dive couple? Reveries still wins. Positioning means choosing.

CHECK UNDERSTANDING

Questions for *discussion* in class

01 *Ruka targets three segments. Is that one position or three? Use Barringer & Ireland to argue.*

STP · POSITIONING

02 *Which of the 7Ps would you fix first for Ruka to be found by AI, and why?*

MARKETING MIX · GEO

03 *Which steps of the sales process should a guesthouse never hand to AI?*

SEVEN-STEP SALES

TUTORIAL ACTIVITY

Groups of 3–4 · 30 minutes

You are the *marketing team*

01 Pick a guesthouse to audit

02 Prompt like a general traveller seeking affordable accommodation in the Maldives

03 Use three different AI assistants (e.g. ChatGPT, Gemini / Google AI Mode, DeepSeek)

04 Record who is named and why; screenshot the top results to share

05 Ask each AI: “Why didn’t you recommend [guesthouse]?” and “What needs fixing for you to recommend it?”

GROUP ASSIGNMENT

“Write a one-year marketing plan for a Maldivian guesthouse, with an executable timeline and budget.”

1 · Audit
AI visibility + listings

2 · STP
+ positioning map

3 · Business Model Canvas
Map the venture

4 · 7Ps with GEO
Each P, AI-ready

5 · 12-month timeline
Quarterly milestones

6 · Budget plan
Cost every action

7 · Pitch
Present the plan

Diagnosis **20** | Plan, timeline & budget **60** | Pitch **20**

Each task tests the four questions from slide 2

Ruka can be...

Found

BY THE MASSES

Consistent, verifiable facts that AI can repeat

Chosen

BY THE RIGHT AUDIENCE

A clear position, with proof points for couples, solo travellers and families

Booked

BY CUSTOMERS WHO BENEFIT THE BUSINESS

AI opens the door; people close the sale and retain the guest

Four lessons: STP chooses who · Brand earns trust · 7Ps make it verifiable · Sales steps close and retain

MY TEACHING PHILOSOPHY

Graduates with *employability skills*

I came from industry. In marketing management roles I sat on the other side of the desk, interviewing graduates. The knowledge was there, but when a real question came there was no reference point, and minds went blank. So I teach students to meet that manager, and surprise them.

Abdulla Muiz Fuad

Questions?

01 **Real local cases**
Maldivian firms like Ruka, not distant examples

02 **Theory → application**
Every concept ends in a decision for a real business

03 **Practise the hard question**
Rehearse the manager's question until the answer comes

*Theory **and** application are worth more to an employer than academia or experience alone.*

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All businesses, logos and assets referenced are used for teaching purposes only, with permission. None of the concepts reflect on real business operations or criticise any business's current operations or strategies. The positioning map is the lecturer's illustrative perception and the "fractured footprint" is a teaching scenario. The slide-4 search and the phone demo are scripted simulations, not live AI; the real AI answers were captured on 4 November 2026.